MUSIC

Taking Charge

With a new EP and her own record label, Indian-American rapper **Raja Kumari** *is now calling the shots*

Svetha Rao, better known as Raja Kumari, had had enough. For seven years, the Indian-American rapper, singer, recording artist and Grammy-nominated songwriter had been dealing with the whims of record labels. "There was a string of men between me and the music," she says. "And so many opinions. I had one label head tell me that Indian girls don't rap. Another said they'll increase the budget for a music video if I don't wear a bindi!" Screw this, she said, and started Godmother, her own label.

Through it, she plans to support younger women artists and provide a safe space for them. The inaugural release on Godmother is her new EP, appropriately titled *HBIC* ("head b**ch in charge"). "It was a statement... it's not like 'Oh, I'm better than anyone'. It's that I'm in control of my life, my music, my brand, my message. With that came such liberation," she says. 'Made in India', a song on the EP, has already made waves, thanks in part to its striking video featuring Bollywood legend Madhuri Dixit. It's an interpolation of Alisha Chinai's indipop classic from 1995—Raja Kumari's version borrows its central refrain, the memorable chorus melody, around which she composes her own interpretation. "I grew up in America, and I would watch this song on Saturday mornings. In America, there were no Indian popstars. When I saw her, that really registered. She was a full-on popstar living her best life. I've always loved this song," she says.

Kumari has, aside from her own music, been a songwriter for globally recognised names, sharing writing credits with the likes of Iggy Azalea, Gwen Stefani,



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RAJA KUMARI'S 'Made in India' is softer than her earlier, more aggressive music. The foundation remains the same, but she's exploring deeper emotions around it.